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Allies shrug as US pushes for Strait of Hormuz patrol

By Paul McLeary, Esther Webber · Jul 28, 2026, 10:52 PM · [View in your browser](#)

European allies are refusing to support a U.S. push to create a joint Strait of Hormuz patrol until they see an enduring ceasefire in the Iran war — the latest sign that Washington's repeated bashing of its closest friends has carried consequences.

Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth is urging the U.K. and France to help lead the naval coalition. But even with the assistance of U.K. Defense Minister Wes Streeting, he's facing skepticism across Europe, according to four British officials and one U.S. official.

Hegseth and President Donald Trump have spent months berating European countries for refusing to get involved in the Iran war. But this effort is the most concerted attempt to seek assistance from allies, and it comes after months of fighting has led to spiraling gas prices, a disaffected public and prolonged closure of the strait.

U.S. and British officials aim to convene an international conference in London that would define roles for countries and determine which warships would hunt for sea mines or protect civilian shipping through the strait, which Iran has effectively halted. But the five officials cautioned the effort has not progressed very far and they didn't expect any movement soon. The people, like others interviewed, were granted anonymity to discuss internal plans.

The U.S. has paused strikes on Iran since Friday after 12 days of renewed bombing, although officials have not specified what led to the halt.

Hegseth floated the patrol idea during a call with Streeting on Friday, according to one British official. The person said the conversation focused on how the U.K. and U.S. can bring allies together to support American defense, rather than backing offensive strikes on Iran.

Hegseth and Streeting then had a call with French Armed Forces Minister Catherine Vautrin on Monday to discuss how to "work together to reassure shipping across the region," one of the U.K. officials said.

Even with the delay, Streeting expects to speak with counterparts from across Europe to coordinate a future multinational mission in the strait, according to two of the U.K. officials.

"The Defense secretary has been having constructive discussions with allies on diplomatic and military efforts to strengthen maritime security, and these will continue in the coming days," one of the two people said.

The Pentagon and the U.K. Ministry of Defence declined to comment. The White House and French Embassy did not respond to a request for comment.

Longtime allies remain frustrated by the Trump administration's refusal to give a heads-up before the American-Israeli airstrikes on Iran began in February, according to two European officials. And they are wary of jumping into a risky new mission when they have not been treated as partners by the White House.

There was "no consultation with Congress, no consultation with allies, just boom," Sen. Chris Coons (D-Del.) said in an interview.

Trump is "deeply frustrated that Congress isn't supporting it, the American people aren't supporting it, our core allies aren't supporting it," he added. "You can't be surprised when you throw a party and you don't invite anybody."

Streetering cautioned Sunday that the U.K. has "not joined and will not join offensive U.S. military action in Iran. That's an area where we have not agreed with the United States. But when it comes to securing maritime freedom and free commercial shipping in the Strait of Hormuz, that's where we are absolutely aligned."

But the latest ceasefire is tenuous at best. Trump told reporters Monday that the two sides are "talking right now" and that there was "a good chance" a new round of diplomacy with Iran could yield a more permanent ceasefire or diplomatic breakthrough.

The Iranian leadership does not appear to agree.

"At present, what exists cannot be described as a ceasefire," said Esmail Baghaei, the Iranian foreign ministry spokesperson.

Commercial shipping in the region remains at a standstill, with dozens of ships full of oil and other cargo bottled up in the gulf.

And delays have only appeared to build in recent weeks. No oil tankers crossed the once popular strait July 27, according to Windward Intelligence, a private security firm that monitors ship traffic in the region. The commercial ship crossings of the narrow Bab al-Mandeb, which is south of the strait and connects the Red Sea with the Gulf of Aden, has fallen 22 percent since the Iran-backed Yemeni Houthis declared a blockade July 20. Tanker transits have fallen 39 percent and Saudi-linked crossings dropped 46 percent, according to the firm.

Two American aircraft carriers are still sitting in the Middle East alongside several other warships, including some carrying about 2,500 Marines. Back-to-back deployments have raised concerns in the Pentagon over keeping them there.

"The particular challenge with Navy vessels, particularly the carriers or submarines out there, is that we are deferring maintenance on them, and at some point you've got to pay the piper," said a former military officer with knowledge of discussions within the Pentagon. "There's some real readiness concerns that have to be seriously discussed as we continue to resource this operation."

Mason Boycott-Owen contributed to this report.

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